

Age-Weighted Democracy

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Abstract

The slogan “one person, one vote” is held to be essential to fair democratic voting procedures. I argue, against its most common interpretation, that the power of one’s vote should decrease with age. The idea of relational equality that it expresses is ambiguous, in ways currently unappreciated, between synchronic and diachronic conceptions of that equality. Standardly assumed is that voters can relate as equals only synchronically in each election. I argue that they can do so diachronically, across the elections throughout their lifetimes. I give a Rawls-style argument that, from the original position, rational persons would select a voting procedure giving more weight to their younger selves. The argument turns on the asymmetric structure of political authority between cohorts: older cohorts have influenced the formative conditions of the young in ways the young can never reciprocate. I argue that the strongest counterargument is committed to a form of epistocracy.

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At the heart of democracy is the idea that citizens have an equal right to participate in political decision-making. Systems that exclude some citizens from voting, or that weight some votes more heavily than others, sit uneasily with that ideal. “One person, one vote” is central to our conception of democracy.

This paper argues that this slogan has been misunderstood. It is ambiguous, in ways not currently appreciated in democratic theory, between two interpretations of “person”. The usual understanding is synchronic: everyone in the political community that exists at the time of an election gets one vote in that

election.¹ However, this paper argues it’s equally plausible to understand equality diachronically—where persons are understood to be whole human lives, extended through time. On this interpretation, equality should obtain between people *throughout* the sequence of elections they live through, not necessarily in each election individually. These two conceptions of equality-bearers, I’ll argue, genuinely conflict, and must be balanced in legitimate concern for equality in political decision-making.

The core of the paper is a Rawls-inspired argument that considerations on the shape of human life and the relative impact of political decisions on its stages—considerations available from the original position—support a system that skews voting power towards youth. Such a system allows us to exercise more control over our political circumstances during the parts of our lives that we actually live to experience, and partially addresses the unidirectional political domination the old exercised over the young before they existed. Thus the ideal democratic voting rule, whatever other properties it has, is *negatively age-weighted*.

After situating my argument within existing literature in §1, I show in §2 that age-weighted voting is fully consistent with “one person, one vote”. This is because vote equality can be understood diachronically, not just synchronically. In §3 I give the core Rawlsian argument for age-weighted voting. Rational people would prefer it from the original position, because it front-loads the political influence of votes in one’s life, increasing the lived impact of those votes relative to age-flat voting, and compensating for two forms of unidirectional political influence I call “domination of the cradle” and “domination from the grave”. In §4 I argue that the best line of defense against this argument—that we gain more information and wisdom as we age, counteracting these asymmetries—supports a kind of epistocracy across the board. In §5 I discuss the shape of the weighting function. In §6 I answer objections.

1 Previous work

There is a small but lively recent literature arguing for age-weighted voting. These arguments generally revolve around the thought that age-weighting is justified because younger voters have more at stake in current political decisions—more future ahead of them, longer to live with the consequences,

¹The synchronic reading is near-universal in existing treatments of vote equality; see e.g. Christiano and Bajaj (2021), Kolodny (2014), and especially Wodak (2025) for detailed discussion of the slogan and how to interpret it. There is a lively debate on synchronic vs diachronic egalitarianism more generally—see McKerlie (1989); Temkin (1993); Daniels (1988); Bidadanure (2021)—but the application of those debates to vote equality is underexplored.

possibly dying young and losing out on overall opportunities for political influence, etc.² My argument takes a different form. It concerns the asymmetric relationships of political authority that already hold between cohorts by virtue of their temporal position alone. These relations generate complaints that no voting rule can dissolve, but that age-flat voting compounds, and age-weighted voting partially answers. I apply a Rawlsian fairness test for voting rules, and consider the temporal structure of complaints and answers that can be known from the original position. The balance of complaints and answers generated by age-weighted voting favors it over age-flat voting.

My argument therefore supports different voting functions than existing stakes-based arguments, threatening to generalize less. A citizen with a terminal diagnosis at twenty-two and a healthy citizen at twenty-two have the same complaint against age-flat voting on my view, even though their futures differ radically. Two citizens with identical expected lifespans can stand in asymmetric authority relations if the elder was politically active while the younger was a child—the elder shaped the younger’s formative circumstances without any possibility of reciprocal influence. And unlike arguments based on the all-affected and all-subjected principles, mine does not generalize to weighting by socioeconomic status or other stakes-affecting properties. Age is special because everyone passes through every age on the way to theirs: the Oldman of today *already had* an election with the same voting weight current twenty-two-year-olds receive, namely when he himself was twenty-two. Equality between persons is preserved diachronically even when it is unequal synchronically. This is the point I’ll argue for in the next section.

2 Age-weighted voting is consistent with democracy

In this section, I’ll argue that age-weighted voting is consistent with a democratic system committed to equality. Key to this argument is a diachronic understanding of relational equality.

²See Parijs (1998), MacAskill (2019), and the future-residence and differential-lifetimes arguments canvassed in Gosseries (2022b). For critical responses, see Volacu (2021), Poama and Volacu (2021), and T. John (2021). Angell (2024) argues for age-weighted voting on the basis of the all-affected and all-subjected principles, responding in part to Bengtson (2020). Other proposals in the neighborhood include lowering the voting age (e.g. Peto (2018); Chan and Clayton (2006)) and youth quotas in parliaments (Bidadanure (2021); for critique see T. M. John (2023)). On the empirical question of whether cohorts vote their generational self-interest, see Jacobs and Matthews (2012), who argues that preferences for short- vs. long-term policies turn more on uncertainties about policy efficacy and durability than on generational interests as such.

2.1 Apartment Painting

Consider the following situation:

Preliminary Apartment Painting: Your apartment needs painting, so it falls to you and your roommates to select a color. None of you has particular expertise as to the effects of color on human well-being, or on the apartment's likely resale value; preference is all that's at stake. The five of you therefore resolve to let democracy reign. A vote is scheduled. All agree that there can be but two possibilities, turquoise and pink; there is division as to which.

What is a fair voting procedure? The most natural thought is that the roommates vote for their favored color, and the majority rules. Now consider a variation:

Apartment Painting: Exactly like *Preliminary Apartment Painting*, except roommates one and two moved in just after the last vote was taken a year ago; and roommates four and five, who have been there all along and voted last year, additionally plan to move out in two months' time.

Does this new information change the fairness of the voting procedure? Intuitively it does. Roommates four and five retain some interest in the color of their apartment. Two months spent staring at a despised color is no trivial inconvenience. But for two reasons, it is not fair. First, the newly-arriving roommates never got a chance to vote on last year's color, and so had this year's color determined by the departing without ever having had a say in the matter. Second, roommates four and five are about to abscond; they'll have to live with the consequences of today's vote for less time.

The analogy to politics is clear. Roommates four and five are like the elderly part of a society, and roommates one and two are its youth. The basic idea behind the *Apartment Painting* intuition is that those subject to initial unreciprocated influence, and sticking around longer, deserve a structurally greater say in the decision. Political voting is such a collective decision. So those arriving later and sticking around longer, the young, deserve a greater say.

2.2 Democracy defined

On some conceptions of what democracy is, what I am suggesting is conceptually confused. The core idea of democracy, according to those conceptions, is a

relation of equality amongst the participants in a collective decision. Christiano and Bajaj (2021) write in the SEP:

The term “democracy”, as we will use it in this entry, refers very generally to a method of collective decision making characterized by a kind of equality among the participants at an essential stage of the decision-making process.

Or take Kolodny (2014)’s characterization. A merely formal conception of democracy—one, he says, too weak to characterize democracy fully, but a core part of any further precisification—

requires not only universal suffrage and equally weighted votes, but also, crucially, freedom of political speech and association.

On these conceptions, democracy almost by definition requires votes to be equally weighted in each election. Any deviation from this undermines the relation of equality that constitutes democracy. So my proposal is a non-starter, at least as a *democratic* one.³ Perhaps it’s still right that we should hold votes and that voting power should skew towards the young, but whatever political system results cannot rightly be called a democracy.

Nor is this concern for equality some idiosyncratic accident of the history of the term, but forms a core part of many attempts to justify democracy, especially attempts that are not entirely consequentialist in character. Kolodny’s main argument for democracy involves the idea that relational equality is a necessary feature of salutary human relationships generally. He writes,

The concern for democracy is rooted in a concern not to have anyone else “above”—or, for that matter, “below”—us: in the aspiration for a society in which none rules over any other. (196)

Anyone who gets more votes than others stands above them in an important sense: their preferences are given structurally more weight. So if two people get unequal votes in a given election, they cannot be relating to each other as equals in so voting.⁴

³Christiano and Kolodny may countenance some exceptions to strict equal weighting—cf. \degressive weighting favoring small-country citizens in EU elections—but neither takes age-weighting seriously. It is the strict reading I target here.

⁴Kolodny focuses the concern for equality on eliminating relations of subordination; others put the concern in terms of equal respect (Brighouse (1996)) or agency (Baker (1998/ed)). The points I make below should generalize to any of these quantities, for each of them exhibits the same trade-off between persons and person-stages.

The first thing I'll do is to argue that on one reasonable understanding of what persons are and in what equality between them consists, my proposal isn't actually inconsistent with the concern for equality that democracy expresses. None should rule over any other, and so we must have equal say in the project of charting our political course. But this leaves undetermined *when* we get that say. Negatively age-weighted voting does give everyone a roughly equal say, on expectation; it just gives them more of that say earlier in their lives than present practice. We need, that is, a diachronic conception of power distribution.

2.3 What are humans, and when do they relate as equals?

What is it for me to relate to you as an equal? That depends a lot on the context. In the apartment-painting case, the naïve idea about how to make the decision as equals was to give everyone's vote equal weight. But that is not the fairest way. The idea of giving everyone a vote proportional to their remaining time in the apartment, or an extra boost for periods they lived in the apartment before they were able to vote, also expresses a kind of equality: it treats everyone's time in the apartment equally. It's not obvious which way of thinking about equality of relation is right in every context. What is clear, though, is that there is some meaningful way, other than equality of influence at each time, for people to relate to each other globally as equals.

Indeed, there are contexts where intuitively equal relationships must have a diachronic understanding of that equality. Take, for example,

Rotating Dinner-Dictator: My friends and I dine together each Saturday. We pick a different restaurant every time. We do not vote every Saturday on a restaurant; instead, we each take a turn as rotating dinner-dictator. The dictator selects the restaurant for that week.

In *Rotating Dinner-Dictator*, the temporary ascension of the dictator expresses no objectionable power asymmetry between us, for the power distribution balances out across time.⁵

This connects to an existing debate on what it means to be an egalitarian. Should our concern be for equality between persons, or person-stages? Some philosophers argue for equality across complete lives (Nagel (1995); Rawls

⁵The rotation strategy as a tool for thinking about diachronic equality traces to McKerlie (1989). Rotation examples are often deployed to stress the limits of a diachronic view rather than its merits; I use it here only to show the coherence of the diachronic view. Thanks to an anonymous referee for pressing this.

(1999)); others defend life-stages (McKerlie (1989); Temkin (1993)); still others develop hybrid or prudentialist views (Daniels (1988); Bidadanure (2021)). I won't take a stand on this general issue. Instead, I'll limit my focus to equality within decision-making contexts. I take *Rotating Dinner-Dictator* to establish that diachronic equality is coherent by showing that there *are* decision contexts in which participants can relate formally as equals in an irreducibly diachronic sense. Whether the features that allow this are present in the political context is a question I take up in the next section.

Existing democratic theorists have taken the concern for equality to be compatible only with what I'll call a *synchronic* understanding of that equality:

Synchronic equality: People relate as equals in making a decision only if they have roughly equal opportunity for input into the making of the decision.

But we've seen that our concern for equality is sometimes broader than the synchronic understanding allows. This suggests that the real concern is sometimes a diachronic one:

Diachronic equality: People relate as equals in making a decision only if that decision takes place in a global decision-making context in which they have roughly equal opportunity of input across decision-making instances.

This broadening of our conception of relational equality brings with it many new choice-points about how to understand the global decision-making context, and how to conceive of the equality of distribution over the course of the decision-making instances that together comprise it. Indeed, one might fear, contexts like the *Apartment Painting* and *Rotating Dinner-Dictator* work so well precisely because they are so well-defined. It's clear why a rotating cast of dictators amongst a stable group constitutes equality: all get to decide on their favorite restaurant a roughly equal number of times over the course of the group's existence.

This suggests that, in order for a global decision-making context to afford a group roughly equal decision-making input, at least two features should hold:

1. Stability of group: The set of decision-makers must be sufficiently stable across decision-making instances for diachronic "balancing out" to be meaningful.
2. Non-arbitrary principle of equality: There must be a public, independently motivated principle specifying in what respect decision-making influence is equalized across instances.

In the next section, I'll consider whether the political realm exhibits features (1) and (2) to a sufficient degree to justify a diachronic conception of decision-making equality.

2.4 Diachronic equality assuming equal lifespans

In the political context, I'll argue in this section, both (1) and (2) are sufficiently satisfied. As regards (1), the exact composition of the electorate changes with time. However, in aggregate, the structure of the polity and its participants is relatively stable and known in advance. Everyone is born, lives for a while, and then dies. The rough shape of one's life is basically similar for everyone, on expectation: most people make it to adulthood, and almost no one lives past 110. So the structure of one's expected group participation in political decision-making is relatively stable and predictable.

What about (2)? I'll first make the simplifying assumption that everyone lives the same fixed amount of time, and articulate a principle of equality given this. In §2.5, I'll relax that assumption.

Say, then, that everyone lives to 100. Then, ignoring some remainders at the boundaries of election years, the number of elections in which everyone will participate is known in advance. The period from 18 to 100 comprises 82 years; at the rate of one election every four years, that's roughly 20 elections over which to spread one's votes.

Since we're assuming for now that everyone has equal time to exist, we can cleanly frame fairness diachronically rather than synchronically. Seen four-dimensionally, everyone has 20 votes to cast. There is a simple fairness principle satisfying (2) here: Every person is given 20 lifetime votes, and so over one's entire life, they get the same structure of political influence. Local inequalities in voting power have justification by reference to this summed equality. Nobody can look back on their lives as a whole, and complain that anyone else received more overall votes.⁶

One potential objection is that lifespans *start* at different times. Thus, given that relational equality is conceived of as a relation between two concrete individuals, the relationship between a young person (Youngman) and an old one (Oldman) will always have Youngman receiving more votes in every election they both participate in. Thus one might worry that relational equality cannot be preserved in this system, even assuming equal lifespans.

However, this objection assumes that power-relevant relationships between two people can only hold while they are both alive. This assumption gets the

⁶A version of the lifetime-votes framing also appears in Mulgan and Couillard (2003).

wrong result in many cases. If I steal your inheritance and then die before you are born, I have intuitively harmed you. If I conspire so that you will only ever be able to buy purple shirts, but then die before you are born, I've intuitively exercised power over you. This holds in the political case as well: those who voted for consequential policies that affected my life exercised political power over me, even though some of them died before I was born. This is inconsistent with the assumption behind this objection.⁷

2.5 Diachronic equality not assuming equal lifespans

Not all lives have equal length. So the principle of diachronic equality justified in the idealized setting can't quite find application in reality. In this non-idealized setting, the way to ensure an outcome as close as possible to diachronically equal voting shares is not local equality, but rather rule by the youngest eligible voters. Some may die before they reach the voting age; but by giving people their full votes early, we maximize the number of people who live to see their full total voting power exercised. Both she who dies at 25 and she who dies at 100 will have exhausted their voting share by 22.

Our discomfort with a dictatorship of the young shows that diachronic equality can't be the whole story. Even if front-loading were the best way to approximate equal expected realized lifetime voting shares under unequal lifespans, it would still mean that large portions of many citizens' lives are governed by decisions in which they have no say.

The contrast with Rotating Dinner-Dictator is instructive: rotation feels fair in part because it is cyclic—there's no set point beyond which you no longer have any prospect for input. Youth-dictatorship, by contrast, installs one segment of the life course as tyrant, after which all are relegated to non-participants. This suggests an inevitable tradeoff between our concern for whole persons across their lives and our concern for contemporary snapshots at each election. How should these concerns be balanced?

Seen diachronically, the age-flat system grants more total voting power to those who live longer: she who lives twice as long past the age of majority accumulates twice as many total votes. This is partly defensible—everyone votes on how the next four years go, and longer-lived citizens are subjected to more four-year terms—but it fails to be completely fair. One reason is that, while the *terms* end after four years, the political consequences do not. Decisions made in one term shape circumstances for decades—wars get started, environmental regulations get set, social programs get funded or defunded.

⁷Compare with (Nagel 1970)'s response to the argument that death cannot harm you, because there cannot be a particular time at which you are harmed.

Younger voters will, on expectation, live with those consequences for longer. This is the *future-residence* intuition. Another is that, since age-flat voting assigns equal weight at every election, those who live longer accumulate more total political influence over their lifetimes—the *differential-lifetimes* concern (see Gosseries (2022b) for discussion of both).⁸

Both of these concerns are forward-looking—they appeal to stakes younger cohorts have in political consequences yet to unfold. Together they illustrate a tension between a synchronic concern for equal standing within each election and a diachronic concern for equal influence across a life. The next section develops an argument that is backward-looking and, I’ll argue, more structurally fundamental: older cohorts have *already* exercised unreciprocated political authority over the young. This favors rebalancing toward the young on grounds independent of differential stakes in the future.

3 Age-weighted voting is preferable from the original position

3.1 A fairness test for voting procedures

Consider an alternate reality:

Cicada-Humans: Humans slumber regularly like cicadas. There is an odd-year cohort, and an even-year cohort. The two never interact; one group’s awakening coincides exactly with the other’s slumbering. They share the same physical space, but different temporal spaces.

In *Cicada-Humans*,⁹ a voting procedure with major votes taken every four years would be completely unjust. Such a “democracy” would give votes only to the even-year cohort; the odd-year cohort would be systematically deprived of the vote, since they always sleep through it.

What would a fair democracy look like for the cicadas? One possibility would be votes every three years, so that the cohorts alternate voting. Another might be temporally extended votes, with the cohort just about to slumber

⁸As Gosseries notes, these two arguments push in different directions regarding the shape of the weighting function.

⁹For earlier philosophical use of cicada-style intergenerational metaphors, see Gosseries (2022a). For discussion of cohort-based federalism and the cohort-coordination problem the case raises, see Gosseries (2016) (esp. p. 108).

casting its votes just before the other cohort awakens to cast theirs. Both of those possibilities seem perfectly fair.

These intuitions suggest a test for the fairness of a voting procedure, in a Rawlsian spirit. Suppose that, before you are born, you are told the basic biological facts of the world you're about to be born into. You don't know how long you in particular will live, nor which birth cohort you'll belong to, but you know the general parameters and possibilities. You are told that every person will be given a certain fixed amount of potential influence to apportion amongst their time slices as they please. You can give everything to your 18-year-old self (should you live that long), or everything to your 80-year-old self (should you live that long), or apportion it equally across all your time-slices, or in any other way you want.

We can see immediately that, in the human-cicada biological structure, we would reject proposals for one vote every four years. Those born to odd cohorts would have a decisive complaint against such a procedure, because they would be deprived of any democratic influence. They would be subjects, not in any sense authors, of the law.

Here's a way of thinking about the test more generally. A voting procedure is **unselectable** if you can know, from the original position, that someone will have a complaint against the procedure that is not balanced out by an answer that they themselves could reasonably be consoled by. Thorny issues loom about how to flesh out the framework of complaints and answers; discussion exists in Rawls (1999), Scanlon (1998), and Rawls (2005). I'll give a feel for how I'm thinking about them by sketching some examples.

Hereditary landed aristocracy is unjust. Why? Because those born commoners have a complaint: They are given a structurally disadvantaged position in society. Nothing balances out this complaint to their reasonable satisfaction, so they are wronged by this arrangement. The arrangement is unfair.

Likewise in our cicada society. Someone born to the odd-year cohort has a complaint against quadrennial voting: it deprives them of political influence, subordinating them entirely to the will of the even-year cohort. This complaint has no answer. No conciliation is forthcoming as to why they don't have votes.

On the other hand, say we are comparing two policies, one which makes everyone better off but the rich better off still, one which makes everyone worse off but more equally so. Perhaps the worse-off have some complaint against the former policy: it results in objectionable inequalities between them and the rich. But here there is an answer that they themselves could reasonably accept: they are better off than they otherwise would have been in the situation of less wealth but more equality.

Two questions are relevant for us. First: Is negatively age-weighted voting

selectable? Second: Is an age-flat voting system selectable? I'll argue, first, that the strongest argument against the selectability of one particular negatively age-weighting function fails, because putatively objectionable inequalities between differently-aged person-stages have a satisfying answer in terms of whole persons, and the correspondingly aged (not coincidentally existing) person-stages that comprise them. Then I'll show that the parallel argument against the selectability of an age-flat function succeeds, because the asymmetric authority that older cohorts inevitably exercise over younger ones—from before the cradle and from beyond the grave—generates complaints without compensatory answers. So negatively age-weighted voting is systematically fairer.

3.2 Is age-weighted voting selectable?

In a given election in a system with age-weighted voting, an older citizen has a potential complaint against younger ones: his vote counts for less than theirs, which treats him as less than their equal in that election.

This objection holds between person-stages (since considered over time, Oldman and Youngman receive the same number of cumulative votes). Oldman's 88-year-old person-stage gets fewer votes than Youngman's 22-year-old person-stage alive concurrently. So Oldman can object to Youngman's advantaged voting position. Considered now, concerning what's to be done in the next four years, Youngman has structurally more influence.

This objection presupposes something about which person-stages can cite which other person-stages as gaining unfair advantage over them. It assumes that the relevant person-stages must all exist at the same slice of time:

Synchronicity of complaints and answers: If a person-stage A at t_1 has a complaint, or answer to a complaint, about the structural relation of equality between them and person-stage B at t_2 , then $t_1=t_2$.

Oldman cites the person-stage of Youngman alive when he is. But why shouldn't the relevant comparison be between Youngman alive now, and Oldman when he himself was 22? If we compare those time-slices, we rediscover equality: Each 22-year-old person-slice received the same number of votes.

Synchronicity of complaints and answers is false. Suppose that we are discussing from the original position whether to give children born between 1950 and 1960 a free college education, while scrapping that program for those born after. This is intuitively, obviously even, an unfair arrangement, one to

which those born later would have a decisive objection. But that objection cannot be lodged wholly synchronically. The unequal relation between the older cohort and the younger cohort is a diachronic thing, comparing person-stages across time, not at a single time. At any time, all the relevantly aged students get the benefit or not equally.

So the attempted complaint lodged by Oldman against relative domination by Youngman has an answer by appeal to the equality between Oldman's 22-year-old self, and Youngman's present one. It is reasonable for Oldman to be consoled by this answer, for it appeals to a relative benefit that he himself received—the real good of having influence over one's own life, not the illicit turns of a rotating tyranny. (Any acceptable age-weighting function, as I argue in §5, must preserve a synchronic floor—no one is to be stamped, in Mill's phrase, as of no account.)

Does this mean that anything goes as far as person-stages are concerned, and that we could fairly select a system like youth dictatorship? An argument from John Stuart Mill is instructive. Mill proposed a scheme according to which each citizen was guaranteed one vote, but those with signs of “superior intelligence and learning” (e.g. having a university degree) could accrue additional votes. His justification is worth quoting at length:

Entire exclusion from a voice in the common concerns is one thing: the concession to others of a more potential voice, on the ground of greater capacity for the management of the joint interests, is another. . . Every one has a right to feel insulted by being made a nobody, and stamped as of no account at all. . . It is only necessary that this superior influence should be assigned on grounds which he can comprehend, and of which he is able to perceive the justice. (Mill (1861), Chapter VIII)

The basis on which Mill advocates apportioning extra votes strikes many as elitist and undemocratic. But there are two different concerns that traditionally factor into the right to vote: competence, and standing. Children are excluded from suffrage on the basis of competence: they are not, it is thought, sufficiently rational and knowledgeable about the affairs of government to be entrusted with influence over it.¹⁰ Frenchmen residing in France are not given votes in elections occurring in Japan not on the basis of competence, but of standing: they don't live there, they have little interest in what happens there, so it expresses no condescension to deprive them of a vote there.

¹⁰Though see O'Neill (2022) for an argument in favor of child enfranchisement.

Mill justifies his proportionate voting scheme by a competence criterion. The more educated someone is, the better they are supposed to be at reckoning out the consequences of political decisions, and perhaps the better their primitive preferences are supposed to be. This has proved controversial. While Brennan (2016) argues for the superiority of epistocracy to full-on democracy, many egalitarians reject Mill's competence-based justification for plural voting on the basis of education.

However, Mill's reasoning can be applied, not to competence, but to standing—without running afoul of egalitarian intuitions. Just as I am not offended when I am kicked out of the polling booths in a country that is not mine, I should not be offended when told that my interest in political decisions decreases in weight on my way out of life. Standing comes not wholesale but in degrees. I am not offended when I am told that, as a junior at my university, I shall get some input in a vote concerning some major change to the curriculum, but not as much as a current freshman. But waning standing doesn't entail absence of standing. An elderly person has a right not to be insulted by being given no vote. He is, after all, still a person, and his interests still count for something. "It is only necessary that this superior influence should be assigned on grounds which he can comprehend, and of which he is able to perceive the justice." Having enjoyed unreciprocated influence over younger generations' formative years is a ground which reasonable people are able to comprehend, and in which they can perceive the justice.

Bidadanure (2021) endorses synchronic constraints alongside diachronic ones: inequalities between young and old are unjust when they "constitute or enable relationships of inequality (such as demonization, exploitation, segregation, stigmatization, marginalization, and domination)" (123). Age-weighted voting, suitably bounded, respects this constraint: so long as no citizen is stamped as of no account, the weighting does not place the old in a relationship of domination under the young. So the synchronic inequality in each election has a diachronic answer. This argument against the selectability of age-weighted voting fails.

3.3 Is age-flat voting selectable?

Is the current system of assigning people equal votes at every life stage selectable? This section gives an argument that it is not.

Oldman and Youngman head as before to the polls. We saw that, in the age-weighted setting, Oldman's complaint against Youngman's larger voting share has an answer that Oldman himself can reasonably accept: when Oldman was young, he received that same larger share. This local inequality has global

compensation.

In the age-flat system, it is Youngman who can lodge complaints against Oldman. I want to consider two different kinds of complaint—one forward-looking and already developed in the literature, one backward-looking and, I think, more structurally fundamental.

The first is in the ballpark of the future-residence argument of Gosseries (2022b): The current election decides the leader for the next several years, but the reasonably foreseeable consequences of political decisions made in those four years extend beyond the term itself. The older generation will cease to be among the affected sooner than younger ones. Yet in an age-flat system their political influence is the same in every election. Call this kind of complaint “domination from the grave”.¹¹

The second category of complaint involves a different and more structurally inevitable kind of domination. By the time they are both at the polls together, Oldman *has already* voted for policies that shaped the formative conditions of Youngman’s life. If Oldman voted against early childhood education programs, or for a war that sends a large contingent of drafted 18-year-olds to the battlefield, Youngman will have suffered the consequences, without ever having had a say in the matter. The early life and formative conditions of every generation—extremely important factors influencing one’s overall life-direction—are shaped unilaterally by previous ones. Call this kind of complaint “domination of the cradle”.¹² Unlike domination-from-grave complaints, which look forwards, domination-of-cradle complaints look backwards, to authority already exercised without an opportunity for reciprocation.

Unlike Oldman’s earlier complaint in the age-weighted setting, these two kinds of complaint have no compensatory answers. Regarding the domination-from-grave complaint, Youngman will never have a corresponding opportunity to dominate Oldman from the grave; Oldman will be long dead by the time Youngman dies. And regarding the domination-of-cradle complaint, Youngman never had an opportunity to vote before birth to balance out Oldman’s domination of him in the cradle. Indeed, considering just the relation between Youngman and Oldman, an age-flat voting system *always* gives Oldman more overall influence over Youngman than vice versa: Oldman exerted influence

¹¹The phrase is somewhat metaphorical, and whether the dead can literally dominate the living is contested; see Beckman (2016).

¹²Related concerns have been explored in work on children’s disenfranchisement and inter-generational domination; see, e.g., Bohman (2011); Lecce (2009); Wall (2012); Pearse (2024). What is new here is the attempt to isolate a distinct complaint that older cohorts politically shape the formative conditions of the young before the young are able to participate in those decisions and propose age-weighted voting as an answer to that complaint.

over the circumstances of Youngman's childhood, young adulthood, and middle age—influence already exerted before Youngman's birth and still in force after Oldman's death.

One might retort that, should Youngman make it to Oldman's age, he'll have a compensatory opportunity to dominate, not Oldman himself, but still-younger generations. But such cycles of oppression, even if symmetrical, are foreseeably suboptimal from the original position. This contrasts with the kind of answer given to the age-weighted voting objection: there, the thing being compensated between the time-slices was a genuine good, namely the ability to control one's circumstances *during* one's life. This, by contrast, is more like the dreary consolation that, having been oppressed, one will later have the opportunity to oppress someone else. And it ignores the separateness of persons: it does nothing to address the complaint Youngman has against *Oldman*.

Now, any system in which existing people make decisions will involve some foreseeable domination of the cradle and from the grave. The claim here is comparative: relative to a reasonably age-weighted system, an age-flat system builds in a gratuitous surplus of these kinds of domination by letting political power accumulate across additional elections with mere longevity. Age-weighted voting answers these complaints more effectively by giving younger people a greater say in the early elections when they start having a say at all.

The complaints generated by domination-of-cradle considerations point to a different kind of age-weighting than would be justified by the future-residence argument. Say that the world were known to end in a year's time. Then future-residence considerations generate no complaints: younger generations and older generations have pretty much the same expected amount of time left on earth. The future-residence argument, taken alone, would not justify age-weighted voting in this case. However, cradle-domination still yields complaints as before: these are grounded in an asymmetric historical fact about cross-generational political influence, influence that *has already* been exercised. Thus these complaints would still demand answers.

Taken together, the two complaints motivate front-loading younger cohorts' voting share. By how much, exactly? I take up that question in §5. But they establish that the defender of age-flat voting now bears a burden of explanation. What could justify refusing even modest front-loading once we take seriously (i) the backward-looking authority that older cohorts have already exercised over the formative conditions of younger ones, and (ii) the forward-looking asymmetry between political influence and exposure to the consequences of that influence?

The most plausible remaining reply is what we might call the **wisdom**

gambit: perhaps political competence increases with age in a way that counterbalances diminished stakes and prior domination. The next section argues that this reply has a deep cost. It commits one, in principle, to competence-weighted voting more generally—in other words, to epistocracy.

4 The wisdom gambit

The most natural way to resist the case for front-loading is to claim that political competence increases with age in a way that counterbalances diminished stakes and prior domination. The thought is simple. On the basis of the cradle- and grave-domination complaints alone, young people would seem to deserve greater influence over present political decisions. But perhaps older voters compensate for these asymmetries by exercising generally better judgment. If age brings wisdom, then giving the young extra weight may be a bad idea, even seen from the original position: it would amplify the voices of young people, who are perhaps most susceptible to novelty, fads, and ideological frenzies, while discounting those who have more life experience and wisdom.

This is not a frivolous reply. It identifies what may look like the single best route back to age-flat voting while retaining an egalitarian justification. But it does so by shifting the justificatory basis of political equality. The earlier argument was structural: it appealed to the backward-looking asymmetry of authority already exercised, and to the forward-looking asymmetry between political influence and exposure to its consequences. The wisdom gambit appeals to competence; it claims that these asymmetries are offset by unequal epistemic positions.

Two issues immediately arise.

First, the claim that political competence increases with age is empirical. Defenders of age-flat voting appealing to the wisdom gambit would have to find data to show, not only that political competence improves with age, but also that it does so in a stable and systematic enough way to match the shape of the complaints raised in the previous section. The empirical data on this are mixed, at best. Ahlfeldt, Maennig, and Steenbeck (2018) and (2022), for instance, give reasons to doubt that older voters are systematically better informed than younger ones. So as a defense of age-flat voting, the wisdom gambit is, at minimum, hostage to further investigation.

But the deeper problem is dialectical. The wisdom gambit concedes a principle whose ramifications are difficult to contain: that outsized structural political power can be justified by appeal to competence. It doesn't just say that older citizens happen to have valuable experience; it claims that such

experience, insofar as it improves political judgment, can legitimately offset the asymmetries identified above in determining who ought to have more influence. It proposes an epistemic balancing of democratic equality.

Once that kind of compensatory appeal is admitted, it is hard to see how it stops with age. Age is, at best, an indirect and noisy proxy for competence. If competence is what does the justificatory work, then there are more direct proxies than age: educational attainment, civic knowledge, performance on tests of political literacy and economic competence, and so on. And if such proxies could justify differential voting power, then the most principled implementation would not be age-flat democracy at all, but a competence-weighted franchise of the kind defended by epistocrats such as Mill (1861) and Brennan (2016). In other words, the wisdom gambit does not merely defend age-flat voting; it implicitly endorses the core claims of epistocracy.

This brings the defender of age-flat voting to a dilemma. If we reject competence as a basis for unequal political power, then the wisdom gambit cannot block the case for at least some front-loading. But if we accept competence as a basis for unequal political power, then it becomes arbitrary to insist on *age* as the proxy mechanism, rather than more direct measures. Either way, the attempt to rescue age-flat voting by appeal to age-based wisdom threatens to collapse into a much more radical view than originally intended.

5 Which weighting function?

I've argued above for the broad outlines of a thesis: that some amount of weighting votes by age is justified, because it helps answer complaints younger generations have against older ones for their domination of the cradle and expected domination from the grave. But I haven't yet committed to a specific weighting function. How much should votes of the young be boosted, and what shape should the function take?¹³

Three things specify a weighting function: its inputs, its shape, and its lower boundary. I'll discuss these things in turn, homing in on some conditions that the function should satisfy, and sketching one particular function that I think plays the role nicely. I don't claim here that this function is uniquely correct—that awaits future work quantifying the force of these complaints and answers—but I hope it provides a concrete idea of the proposal.

On inputs: The core argument I give in §3 supports taking age alone as an input to the weighting function. Thus it occupies a unique place in the

¹³Thanks to an anonymous referee for pushing me on this important point.

literature; as I'll explain below, existing arguments threaten to generalize to factors beyond just age in ways that many may find intuitively less palatable.

If the argument for age-weighting were driven purely by future-residence concerns, it's hard to see how we wouldn't be pushed to a more fine-grained scheme: different weighting functions for different people, based on all actuarial properties influencing how long they can be expected to live. As noted in §1, someone with a terminal cancer diagnosis should get a low future-residence-based vote, regardless of whether they are young or old. The differential-lifespans argument threatens to generalize in the opposite direction (a tension Gosseries notes): if the goal of age-weighted voting is to re-balance lifetime voting power to those dying young, then our 22-year-old terminal cancer patient should receive *more* votes than her healthy 22-year-old counterpart, and also more than her 88-year-old co-patient. For both of these arguments, age is merely one actuarial proxy among many tracking the thing that actually matters.

Arguments grounding age-weighting in the all-affected and all-subjected principles—most prominently Angell (2024)—face a more capacious version of this same worry. Age affects how much one stands to be affected by, or subjected to, a given law; but so do many other properties. A high earner is (arguably) more affected by an upper-bracket income tax hike than a low one. If degree of affectedness settles voting weight, the principle threatens to deliver conclusions of just the sort nineteenth-century defenders of the property franchise once welcomed—more political say for those with more economic stake. This generalization can be resisted, but doing so requires resources beyond the principle itself.

The central argument of §3, however, turns on the backward-looking asymmetry of political authority between cohorts—the cradle-domination complaint—which is specifically generational. Age is unique in that everyone passes through ages in the same order. This is central to §2's argument that age-weighted voting is consistent with democratic political equality. Not everyone passes from poor to rich, or vice-versa. But everyone was young, had their circumstances determined by their elders, and only later started voting. Thus the cradle-domination complaint doesn't generalize to other actuarial axes.

On shape: The argument of §3 alone doesn't deliver a unique weighting function, but it does suggest constraints. First, the function should be *monotonically non-increasing in age*. Cradle-domination complaints only accumulate with age: each additional year a person has lived as a fully enfranchised adult is another year over which they have exercised unidirectional political authority over younger cohorts. At no point does this asymmetry reverse, so weights should not rise as one ages. Second, the function should *strictly decrease over at least some range of adult life*. This is to answer the complaints of §3.3. Third,

the function should be *bounded within a reasonable range*. On the low end, as Mill observes, “every one has a right to feel insulted by being made a nobody, and stamped as of no account at all.” The elderly remain subject to the law, retain forward-looking stakes, and possess civic standing; their share cannot be so small as to mock those facts. On the high end, if the youngest cohort’s vote is, say, fifty times that of the oldest, we’ve plausibly overcorrected.

MacAskill (2019) proposes giving everyone six votes at age 18, decreasing by one every decade, bottoming at one after age 68. This function satisfies the criteria, and is fairly easy to understand. (One might demand that the function be continuous: this involves a tradeoff with transparency, discussed in §6.) Singling out one function within the family requires empirical work quantifying how strong cradle- and grave-domination complaints are at different ages, how durable typical policies turn out to be, what relevant life expectancies are. The most that follows from §3 is that some negatively age-weighted function within this family is preferable to age-flat voting; further empirical and normative work is needed to pin one down.

On lower boundary: The literature on the kind of domination I’ve called “of the cradle” generally proposes lowering the age of enfranchisement as a remedy. I am sympathetic to this argument. However, that strategy has limits. The minimum voting age is motivated by a *competence floor*: a five-month-old baby pushing buttons in a voting booth would just be pressing them randomly. But to the extent one thinks the present floor is too high—that 16-year-olds, or even 14-year-olds, are competent to vote—the case for lowering it and the case for age-weighting are complementary, not competing.

Even if the voting age were lowered to zero, *and* we could somehow elicit competently held preferences from newborns, it would not eliminate unreciprocated domination of the cradle. Policies put in place before our births shape our early life to a large degree; if a war starts before you are born and as a result they defund your preschool, you are harmed without a say in the matter, even if you start voting against the war from the moment of birth. Thus we should have a serious discussion about lowering the competence threshold, but it does not replace the need for age-weighted voting.

6 Remaining worries

In this section I address lingering worries and objections.

6.1 Transparency

A great benefit of age-flat voting is its simplicity. This simplicity gives elections a kind of intuitive legitimacy: everyone can understand how a majority vote can be seen to express the will of the people. More recently, though, movements have gained traction arguing that this simplicity is deceptive. Ranked-choice voting is being more widely practiced despite its complexity, and this has not come with a collapse of perceived legitimacy. The same holds for proportional representation schemes like the d'Hondt method used in Scotland's Holyrood elections, and the various PR systems in place across the EU: arithmetically more demanding than first-past-the-post, but widely accepted as legitimate by the populations they serve.

Therefore, complex voting systems are not automatically perceived as illegitimate. What matters is that the complexity is motivated by considerations that the voters can appreciate the fairness of—whether it's the superiority of ranked-choice voting over a winner-take-all system, or protecting small states' interest in the electoral college. My hope here is to have made such a case for the justice of age-weighted voting.

These considerations also suggest an additional desideratum for the voting function: A simpler function should be preferred over a needlessly complicated one, because simpler functions are easier for the population to understand and to perceive as legitimate. This dovetails nicely with my philosophical motivation for restricting the input to age alone: a voting system relying on all sorts of demographic and health data *would* seem to tread into the territory of the overly baroque.

6.2 Ageism

A natural worry arises whenever there is a proposal to weaken the enfranchisement of a class of people: that doing so expresses disrespect for the relatively disenfranchised class. In this case, that class is the elderly—a group which is already among society's disadvantaged and vulnerable demographics. Will age-weighted voting worsen the problem of ageism?

Two versions of this objection have to be distinguished. First is the claim that age-weighted voting treats the elderly as less important as such. The argument of §2 goes a long way to defuse this concern: There is a natural way of expressing how the elderly *are* treated as equals in age-weighted democracy. And there is a limit to how disadvantaged they can become, synchronically: as discussed in the last section, it's important that votes never bottom out at zero or trivial weight. The weighting is justified according to a principle the

elderly themselves should be able to see the virtue in—giving each generation, including theirs, more control over its lived circumstances, and compensating them for the lack of a say over the conditions of their early life.

The second version of the objection is empirical—that age-weighted voting will worsen the problem of ageism more generally. This is an empirical question, but it cuts both ways: there are reasons to think that age-flat voting yields perverse incentives that are sub-optimal from a whole-society point of view.¹⁴ The pension system in almost every developed country is underfunded; more promises have been made to older generations than younger ones can reasonably bear. And housing policy over past decades has systematically benefited older generations.¹⁵ The debates about empirical tradeoffs are worth having, but there is some reason to think that rebalancing vote distribution towards the young could correct some of these structural problems.

6.3 Just get the young to vote?

In most developed democracies, young people vote at lower rates than older people, though the gap varies.¹⁶ Thus a natural objection to age-weighting: isn't the simpler remedy just to fix turnout, not to overhaul the voting system? Get the young to actually vote, and age-weighting may become unnecessary.

I support efforts to increase youth voting participation. But even if they fully succeeded with equal participation, cradle-domination complaints would still exist and demand redress. In the initial period of life, young people had *no* input into political decisions; they were subjects without being authors of the law. Thus even if they participate and vote equally going forward, there remains a standing cumulative power differential between them and older cohorts. Only a tool like age-weighted voting begins to address this asymmetry. Equal vote participation does not.

Age-weighted voting arguably has an auxiliary benefit here: it reshapes political parties' incentives to spend more effort courting the youth vote, thus making it rational to adopt policies more responsive to youth preferences. So age-weighted voting might well *lead* to increased youth turnout by giving politicians more of a reason to care what younger voters think.

¹⁴On aging democracies' systematic over-weighting of elderly interests in representation and policy outcomes, see Buchmeier and Vogt (2024).

¹⁵On pension underfunding, see OECD (2023b); on housing affordability, see OECD (2023a).

¹⁶See Smets (2012) for cross-national data.

7 Conclusion

Negatively age-weighted voting is fairer than present age-flat practice. It's in our nature to want self-determination, and some of that concern for self-determination is diachronic. Every generation has suffered a lack of determination over its early life, and had its formative years shaped by factors its elders decided for it. Age-flat voting lets this asymmetry stand; age-weighted voting is a structural step toward addressing it. The argument I give here has a narrow conclusion: it does not justify weighting votes by stakes in general, or by longevity, or by individual life expectancy—only by age, since age alone has the inevitable one-way temporal structure that my argument requires. Defenders of age-flat voting now owe answers to the cradle- and grave-domination complaints.

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